

RACEDRIVER GRID

For some reason, the latest *Need for Speed: Pro Street* hasn't received the same warm welcome from gamers as the earlier *NFS* series starting from *NFS: Underground*. *NFS*s have the feeling of going through the streets at lightning speeds and braking from those speeds to a complete halt in 2 seconds, taking sharp 90 degree turns at such speeds with gravity working overtime to stop you from crashing into a building or someone's living room. On the other hand, for the console, there's the *Gran Turismo 5*, which has always given console gamers a mild sensation of racing simulation.

Seriously though, games like *GTR2*, *Live for Speed*, *rFactor* and *Richard Burns Rally* for the PC are more authentic and exhibit immersive simulations than the watered down arcade games.

Here's where Codemaster's all new arcade-sim racer *Race Driver: Grid* comes into the picture. The last release of *Colin McRae - Dirt* has been known for its graphics. It's the same engine that's used in *Grid*.

Each game mode has a distinct handling characteristics for the cars. If you thought you were good at *NFS* drifting, then you have to try *Grid*.

Multiplayer works considerably well. The netcode is great and cars don't hover or juggle around the roads like other racing games. The real



**Finally! An arcade racer
that respects some laws
of physics...**

opponents can be annoying as you'll find yourself being boxed into barriers, and straight into walls on some narrower tracks. The tracks are well detailed and there is a good variety of them. There're race circuits, as well as street tracks to industrial zones for drifting!

The replay is just spectacular with realistic camera motion. *NFS* had done away with the cockpit views years ago, and is good to see it back in a racing title like *Grid*. There's a fair amount of detail in the car and it adds to the mood.

Dents, smashed corners, scraped patches of paint are quite normal. It's amazing how much more refined *Grid* is than *Dirt* was. The game absolutely gorgeous and is undoubtedly one of the best looking racers - maybe even better than *Dirt*.

Simply put, *Grid* is a fun arcade racer, garnished with bits of simulation characteristics—it's more challenging than *NFS* for sure, and it's a proper racing game with focus on diligent driving and worrying less about how flashy your car looks. Since its demo release a few weeks, there's been enthusiasm from simulation and arcade racing fans alike.

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Rating: 8/10
Developer: Ubisoft Montreal
Publisher: Ubisoft
Platforms: PC, Xbox 360 and
Playstation 3